



Playing Around With VirtualBox-OSE

VirtualBox is one of the easiest desktop virtualisation solutions available for Linux. What's more, it has an open source version! This article examines why you might want to use it, and does a run-through of creating a virtual machine (VM) with VirtualBox's Open Source Edition (OSE).

Linux users, especially distro-hoppers, love to experiment with different options. Yet, at times, it can be a problem to install each new distro on a hard disk partition. A virtual machine on your own computer lets you try out a distro without messing with partitioning. If found to be good, you can then install the distro to a hard disk partition, for regular use. Another scenario: what if you use Linux as your main OS, but also need to use Windows-only software like AutoCad or MS Access? A VM with Windows installed in it solves this problem. VMs are useful in many other situations, which are too numerous to list.

Previous articles in *LINUX For You*, and on the Web, will give you all the information you want on virtualisation—so we're not covering it here. Out of the various virtualisation products available today, like VMware, Bochs and QEMU, this article explores the Oracle (previously Sun) VirtualBox Open Source Edition (VirtualBox-OSE). (For a list of differences between the

OSE, which has been released under GPLv2, and Oracle's binary Personal Use and Evaluation 'PUEL' version, visit <http://www.virtualbox.org/wiki/Editions>.)

I'm using the latest stable OSE version, 3.2.8, running on an Ubuntu 10.04 32-bit desktop edition (i.e., the 'host' OS). It's important to remember that any OS running 'inside' a VM is called a 'guest' OS.

Installing the OSE

Good news for Ubuntu 10.04 users: installing the OSE from the repositories is as simple as typing `sudo apt-get install virtualbox-ose virtualbox-ose-dkms`. If your distribution does not include OSE in its repository, you can download it from <http://www.virtualbox.org/wiki/Downloads> (choose the open source version). After downloading the bz2 archive, you have to manually extract it, and there are a lot of other steps and tools required—but you can follow the complete instructions at http://www.virtualbox.org/wiki/Build_instructions.